

For Joe Frazier, It's as Clear as Black and White

One thing comes through when Joe Frazier sings his songs. His sincerity. The reviews have been of the highest praise. The people at the tables in the Rainbow Grill, high atop the RCA Building, bang their palms together excitedly. Joe Frazier was an honest fighter. He is an honest entertainer.

The other night, on his day off, Joe Frazier toiled down the Jersey Turnpike to his home in Philly. When he walked in, he got a casual hello from Florence and from the five kids. They were grouped around the TV, absorbed in watching "Roots."

"How can you like white people after what they done to us?" Marvis Frazier said to his father. "We oughta hate them."

Joe Begs to Differ With Marvis

"What the hell are you talking about?" said Joe Frazier.

"The whipping, and the killing and those terrible chains."

Joe Frazier's tongue swept across his lower lip, the way it does whenever he is excited. "Hey, listen. You kids shut off that set and get your behinds in this room. I want to talk to you."

Marvis and his four sisters followed Joe Frazier. "You see this house you live in, this great big beautiful house? I worked my ass off for this, and you know who helped me? White folks and black folks, both."

"You see the clothes you're wearing? The good food you eat? You, Marvis, how many 16-year-old kids do you know, white or black, who drive a Cadillac, the way you do?"

"To me, it's all people, all one. Just remember that. That's the way it's always been, and that's the

way it's always gonna be around this house. You mean to tell me you gonna let one TV show change all that?"

"Now you all go back and turn on your TV and watch your show, and don't let me ever hear you talking that way again."

One long, wailing note from where a fighter plays singer, an actor plays the part of a fighter. In the new musical drama, "Piaf," Lou Bedford is Marcel Cerdan. Edith Piaf was, of course, the greatest French torch singer since the Statue of Liberty, and Marcel Cerdan



YOUNG IDEAS

By DICK YOUNG

was the great love of her abundantly sensuous being.

Marcel Cerdan won the world's middleweight crown in 1948, at age 32, by battering Tony Zale in Jersey City, and lost it to Jake LaMotta at 33. Cerdan's left shoulder was torn out joint in the first round, and he battled Jake one-handed till it was stopped in the 10th. A rematch was made quickly, and it was while flying to America to keep the date that Cerdan was killed. The plane went down in the Azores.

For his role, Lou Bedford studied films, over and over again, of the Cerdan-LaMotta fight, and has been working out for five weeks at the North Shore Health

Club in Manhasset, Bedford, in his service days at Fort Knox, held the middleweight crown of the 2d Army. There is a remarkable resemblance to Cerdan, the one exception being Bedford's hairless chest.

Lou Bedford is somewhat older than Emile Griffith, but in equally remarkable shape. He does not spar during his workouts, he says, "because I have \$5,000 worth of caps in this mouth!"

Previews of "Piaf" are being shown at the Playhouse on 48th, off 9th, where the official opening takes place next Monday. Co-producer is Eddie Vallone, who has a sports story all his own to tell.

Eddie Vallone grew up in the Bronx with the Richman boys. Milt Richman grew up to become sports ed of the UPI; Art Richman is P.R. man for the Mets. Eddie Vallone became a third baseman for Fargo in the Northern League. That was 25 years ago.

Playing against him, for Eau Claire, was a kid shortstop named Hank Aaron, also in his first season.

"I hit more home runs than Hank Aaron did that year," recalls Eddie Vallone. "He was a line drive hitter. He hit nine."

Andy Cohen Preserved Aaron's Swing

"I remember one night, some Braves scouts showed up to inspect their farmhands. They made remarks about how Aaron would wriggle the bat behind his ear as he waited for the pitch. They said that would have to be changed. Andy Cohen was the Eau Claire manager and he told them nothing doing, you let that kid alone."

"So, the way I look at it, Andy Cohen is as responsible as anyone for the great career Aaron has had. If he had let them tamper with Henry's style, who knows? They could have ruined him."